EW 8 NEGATIVE STRUCTURES

44. NEGATIVE STRUCTURES

ALL NEGATIVES IN FRENCH HAVE 2 (OR MORE) PARTS : BE CAREFUL NOT TO OMIT ONE

not	**ne . . . pas**	never	**ne . . . jamais**
no-one	**ne . . . personne**	nowhere	**ne . . . nulle part**
not . . . anyone	**ne . . . personne**	not …anywhere	**ne . . . nulle part**
only	**ne . . . que**	nothing	**ne . . . rien**
no more	**ne . . . plus**	not …anything	**ne . . . rien**
no longer	**ne . . . plus**	not in the least	**ne . . . nullement**
not . . . either	**ne . . . pas . . .non plus**	neither . . . nor	**ne . . . ni . . . ni [object]**
no, not a single	**ne . . . aucun(e)**	neither . . . nor	**ni . . . ni . . . ne [subject]**

45. a) as a general rule, the negative particles go on either side of the verb

b) in compound tenses the negative particles go on either side of the auxiliary verb:

- I haven't seen his new film : *Je n'ai pas vu son nouveau film*
- I never said that : *Je n'ai jamais dit cela*

EXCEPTIONS : **ne …. personne**

ne …. nulle part

ne …. que

- We didn't meet anyone : *Nous n'avons rencontré personne*
- They didn't go anywhere : *Ils ne sont allés nulle part*
- He drank only wine : *Il n'a bu que du vin*

c) If the infinitive is in the negative, the 2 parts of the negative stand together:

- I persuaded her not to leave : *Je l'ai persuadée de ne pas partir*
- She was obliged not to say anything : *Elle était obligée de ne rien dire*

EXCEPTIONS : **ne …. personne**

ne …. nulle part

He asked not to see anyone : *Il a demandé à ne voir personne*

d) With *ne . . . que* the *que* is placed immediately before the phrase it restricts
e.g. in the typically lax English `He only goes to market on Fridays', `only' in fact restricts `on Fridays'. Hence the position of *que* in: *Il ne va au marché que le vendredi*

e) where 2 or more negative particles are used together the order is:

1. plus 2. jamais 3. rien/personne

- He never says anything any more : *Il ne dit plus jamais rien*
- He never sees anyone anymore : *Il ne voit plus jamais personne*

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ne ... plus : NO MORE, NO LONGER, NONE LEFT

- No thank you, I don't want any more :*Merci, je n'en veux plus*
- Sorry, there are not any left! :*Désolé, il n'y en a plus (il n'en reste plus)*

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ne ... jamais : NEVER

- I've never seen him (her) : *Je ne l'ai jamais vu (vue)*

nb *jamais* can stand without *ne* to mean `ever' and on its own, meaning `never' in answer to a question

- Have you ever been to Germany? : *Etes-vous jamais allé en Allemagne?*
  No, never. *Non, jamais*

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ne.... rien : NOTHING, NOT ANYTHING

- We didn't buy anything : *Nous n'avons rien acheté*

nb *rien* can be used on its own in answer to a question

- What did you do yesterday? Nothing. : *Qu'est-ce tu as fait hier? Rien*

nb *rien* can stand at the beginning of a sentence, as the subject of the verb, where it is followed by *ne*

- Nothing's simpler : *Rien n'est plus facile*

ne .... personne : NOBODY, NOT ANYBODY

- see sections b) & c) above

nb **Personne** can be used on its own, like **rien**, in answer to a question

- Who is in the café? No-one. : *Qui est dans le café? Personne.*

nb **Personne** can stand at the beginning of a sentence, as the subject of the verb, where it is followed by **ne**

[NOTE that there is no agreement on the past participle]

- Nobody came to see us : *Personne n'est venu nous voir*

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ne .... nulle part : NOWHERE, NOT ANYWHERE

- I can't see them anywhere : *Je ne les vois nulle part*

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ne .... aucun : emphatic NO, NOT A SINGLE . . .

- There's no doubt : *Il n'y a aucun doute*
- It's of no importance : *Cela n'a aucune importance*
- I've no idea : *Je n'ai aucune idée*

nb i) *aucun* AGREES with the following noun
ii) *aucun* can NEVER be plural (EXCEPTION: **d'aucuns** = some people)
iii) *aucun* & *pas* NEVER go together: the negative is complete with **ne . . . aucun**

iv) *aucun(e)* cannot be used with, or refer to, collective nouns (e.g. argent, temps),

i.e. where you cannot have UN/UNE -----

- I have no money : *Je n'ai pas d'argent*

46. ONLY/SIMPLY/MERELY/NOTHING BUT + verb : ne faire que + infinitive

ie when "only", "merely" etc qualify a verb

- He merely smiled : *Il n'a fait que sourire* (ie he did nothing but smile)
- They do nothing but eat : *Ils ne font que manger* (ie they do nothing but eat)
- He only writes novels : *Il ne fait qu'écrire des romans* (ie that is all he does)

47. NE....NULLEMENT translates the English `not in the least' and `in no way'

- That does not surprise me in the least : *Cela ne m'étonne nullement*
- He's in no way responsible : *Il n'est nullement responsable*

48. NEITHER / EITHER / NOR

a) negative verb + either : **NE (verb) PAS...NON PLUS** (placed at end of clause)
- I didn't see the man either : *Je n'ai pas vu l'homme non plus*
- He didn't come either : *Il n'est pas venu non plus*

b) neither of us/you/them + verb:

nous/vous/ils NE (verb) ..... NI L'UN NI L'AUTRE
(placed at end of clause)

- Neither of them believed him : *Ils ne l'ont cru ni l'un ni l'autre*

- Neither of us wanted to leave : *Nous ne voulions partir ni l'un ni l'autre*

c) neither + VERB + nor + VERB : **NE (verb) NI NE (verb)**
- He neither drinks nor smokes :*Il ne boit ni ne fume*

d) VERB + neither (NOUN) + nor (NOUN): **NE + verb + NI (NOUN) + NI (NOUN)**
We have neither pens nor paper :*Nous n'avons ni stylos ni papier* [NB no *des*]

e) neither (NOUN) + nor + (NOUN) + VERB **NI (NOUN) NI (NOUN) + NE + verb**
Neither Paul nor Jean arrived on time :*Ni Paul ni Jean ne sont arrivés à l'heure*